

Biblical Criticism

A Light Seminary-Level Overview of the Major Methods

What “criticism” means here

In biblical studies, criticism is a technical academic term for disciplined methods used to investigate the text, its wording, historical setting, sources, literary form, editorial shaping, and place within the canon. It does not automatically mean attacking or rejecting Scripture.

The Major Critical Methods

Method	Primary Question
Textual Criticism	What wording most likely represents the earliest recoverable form of the text?
Historical Criticism	What historical circumstances, people, events, institutions, and cultural realities illuminate this passage?
Source Criticism	What earlier written or oral sources may stand behind the final text?
Form Criticism	What kind of smaller literary unit is this, and how may it have functioned before being placed here?
Redaction Criticism	How did the author/editor select, arrange, adapt, or emphasize inherited material - and why?
Literary / Narrative Criticism	How does the final form of the text work as literature - structure, plot, repetition, characterization, irony, and themes?
Rhetorical Criticism	How is the writer or speaker trying to persuade, move, or shape the audience?
Social-Scientific / Cultural Criticism	How do customs, kinship, economics, politics, honor/shame, patronage, purity, slavery, marriage, and other social structures inform the text?
Canonical Criticism	How does this passage function within the finished book and within Scripture as a whole?

A simple way to remember it: some methods look behind the text, some look at the text in its world, and some look at the final text as we now have it.

What Each Method Is Doing

1. Textual Criticism

Compares surviving manuscripts and variants to determine the earliest recoverable wording. Famous discussion points include Mark 16:9-20, John 7:53-8:11, and 1 John 5:7-8.

2. Historical Criticism

Locates the passage in time and place. Ask: Who is speaking? To whom? Under which king, empire, covenantal period, crisis, or social setting? Historical anchors can radically clarify meaning.

3. Source Criticism

Asks whether the author drew on earlier sources or traditions. The Bible itself sometimes names sources, while scholars also propose sources behind books such as the Pentateuch or Synoptic Gospels.

4. Form Criticism

Identifies smaller literary forms - lament, hymn, proverb, parable, genealogy, miracle story, legal formula, prophetic oracle - and asks how that form functions.

5. Redaction Criticism

Studies what an author does with received material. In the Gospels, differences in arrangement, wording, omission, or emphasis may reveal each Evangelist's theological purpose.

6. Literary / Narrative Criticism

Reads the final text closely as literature. It pays attention to repetition, plot, characterization, point of view, contrast, structure, irony, and recurring themes.

7. Rhetorical Criticism

Examines argument and persuasion. Especially useful in letters such as Romans or 1 Corinthians, where the author is developing a case rather than listing disconnected doctrines.

8. Social-Scientific / Cultural Criticism

Reconstructs the social world assumed by the text: inheritance, kinship, patronage, slavery, marriage, land, purity, honor/shame, Roman citizenship, temple worship, agriculture, and more.

9. Canonical Criticism

Asks what a passage means within the completed biblical canon. The same text can be studied in its original historical setting and also in relation to the broader storyline of Scripture.

Important balance

These methods can be used with very different theological assumptions. The method itself is a tool; the conclusions depend on the evidence, the interpreter's assumptions, and how cautiously the method is applied.

A Practical Reading Workflow

Before moving from a verse directly to personal application, work through the text in layers:

TEXT	What words do we actually have? Are there meaningful manuscript variants?
HISTORY	Where are we in the biblical timeline? What events or powers shape the setting?
AUTHOR / AUDIENCE	Who is speaking or writing, to whom, and for what immediate reason?
CULTURE	What customs or social structures would the original audience have understood automatically?
FORM / GENRE	Is this narrative, law, poetry, wisdom, prophecy, Gospel, letter, apocalypse, or another form?
REDACTION / RHETORIC	Why is the material arranged or emphasized this way? What response is the author seeking?
BOOK	How does this passage serve the argument, story, or theology of the whole book?
CANON	How does it relate to the broader biblical story and other Scripture?
APPLICATION	What enduring theological principle legitimately carries from their world into ours?

The interpretive movement

THERE -> PRINCIPLE -> HERE

The key discipline

Before asking, “What does this Scripture say to me?” first ask, “What was this Scripture saying there?” Historical and literary context do not make Scripture less applicable; they help make our application harder to manipulate and more faithful to the text.

Example: Deuteronomy 8

- Historical setting: Israel is near the end of the wilderness period and is preparing to enter Canaan.
- Speaker and audience: Moses addresses Israel before settlement in the land.
- Immediate concern: prosperity - houses, wells, vineyards, crops, wealth - may tempt Israel to forget YHWH.
- Enduring principle: abundance can produce self-sufficiency and spiritual forgetfulness; God's people must remember the source of what they possess.
- Interpretive caution: “houses you did not build” is first about Israel's historical situation, not a detached promise that every believer will receive a house.

WHO • WHEN • WHY • CONTEXT